

Political engagement, political polarization and wellbeing in Latin America

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Political Participation and Well-Being

- ▶ A central theme in the economics of well-being is the role of social relationships and relational goods.
- ▶ Activities such as participation in clubs, associations, or religious groups are consistently associated with higher well-being.
- ▶ Political participation may operate through similar channels:
 - ▶ social interaction and belonging
 - ▶ shared identity and collective purpose
 - ▶ opportunities for cooperation
- ▶ Under this view, political engagement could contribute positively to well-being.

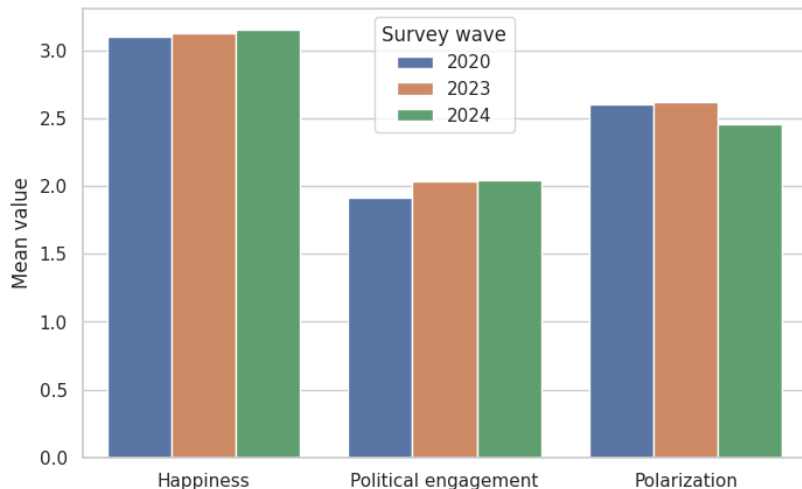
Polarization and Relational Goods

- ▶ Increasing political polarization may alter the nature of political participation.
- ▶ Interactions are less oriented toward sociability and more toward conflict and opposition.
- ▶ Encounters with others may become:
 - ▶ identity-reinforcing rather than relationship-building
 - ▶ adversarial rather than cooperative
- ▶ As a result, social ties may become instrumentalized (means to defeat opponents rather than ends in themselves).
- ▶ This transformation may weaken or even reverse the positive effects of participation on well-being.

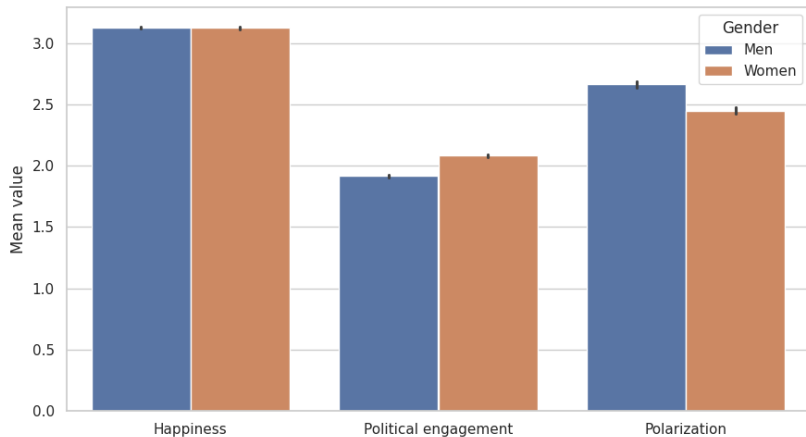
Data

- ▶ Source: Latinobarómetro (2020, 2023, 2024)
- ▶ Multi-country surveys across Latin America (pooled cross-sections; $N = 58,623$)
- ▶ Key variables:
 - ▶ **Well-being:** self-reported life satisfaction (1–4 scale)
 - ▶ **Political engagement:**
 - ▶ “How interested are you in politics?” (1–4 scale)
 - ▶ Proxy for political interest (attitudinal engagement)
 - ▶ **Polarization:**
 - ▶ Left–right self-placement (0–10 scale)
 - ▶ Used to construct a proxy (distance from center)
 - ▶ **Controls**

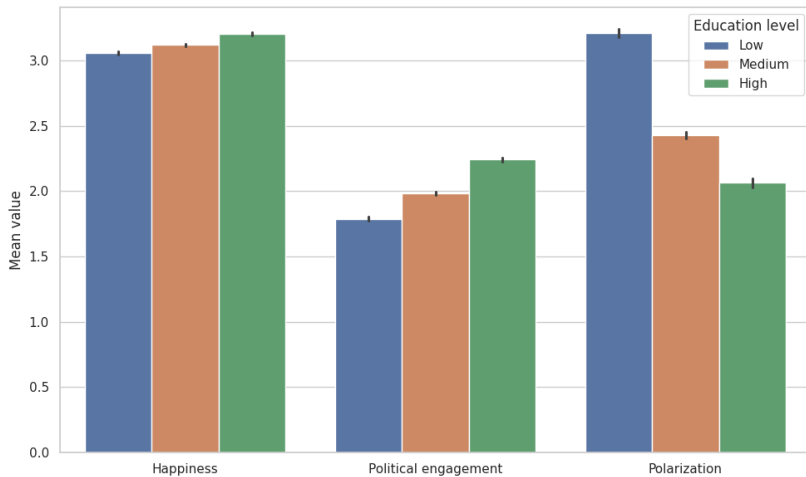
Changes across survey waves



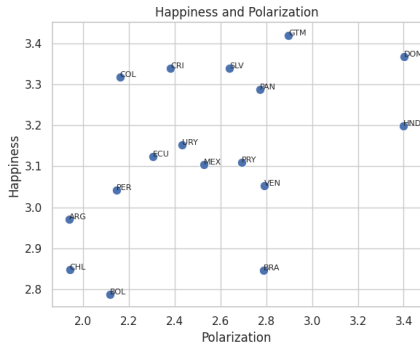
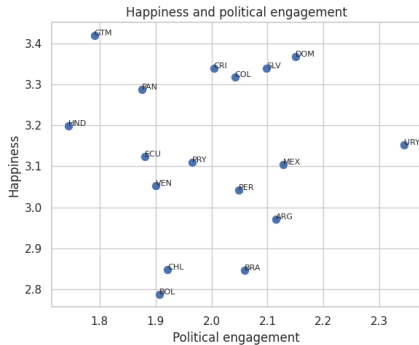
Gender



Education level



Political participation and well-being



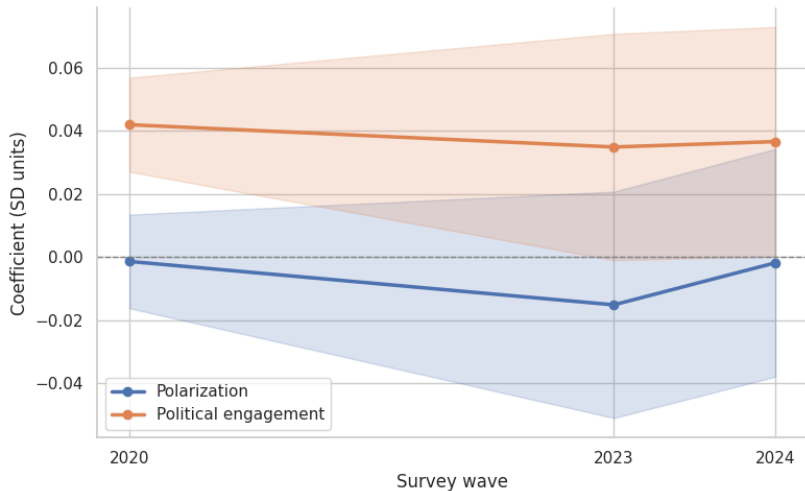
Preliminary Results

	(1)	(5)	(6)
Engagement	0.038***	0.018***	0.018***
Polarization	-0.008		
Pol (within)		-0.002	-0.002
Pol (context)		0.132	0.132
Eng $\times$ Pol (within)			0.001
Eng $\times$ Pol (context)			-0.047*
Controls	No	Yes	Yes
Country FE	No	Yes	Yes
Wave FE	No	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	35,058	35,058	35,058
Adj. R^2	0.002	0.073	0.073

- ▶ Standard errors clustered at the country level
- ▶ Preliminary patterns remain broadly consistent across alternative specifications

Appendix

Associations with happiness by wave



Decomposition of Polarization

$$\text{Polarization}_{i,c,t}$$

$$\text{Polarization}_{c,t}^{\text{context}} = \overline{\text{Polarization}_{c,t}}$$

$$\text{Polarization}_{i,c,t}^{\text{within}} = \text{Polarization}_{i,c,t} - \overline{\text{Polarization}_{c,t}}$$

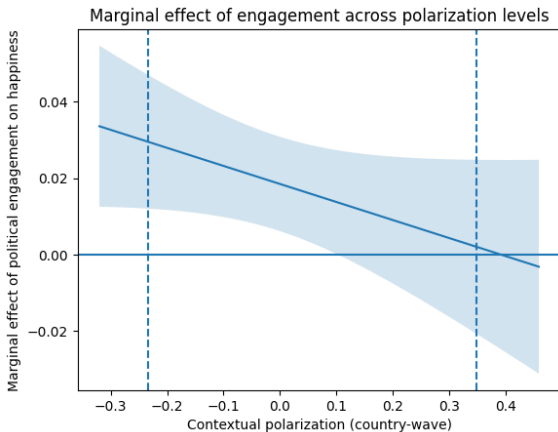
- ▶ Total = Within + Context
- ▶ Within: deviation from country-wave mean
- ▶ Context: average polarization in country-wave

Exploratory Empirical Strategy

$$WB_{ict} = \beta_1 Eng_{ict} + \beta_2 Pol_{ict}^w + \beta_3 Pol_{ct}^c + \beta_4 (Eng \times Pol^w)_{ict} \\ + \beta_5 (Eng \times Pol^c)_{ict} + X_{ict} + \alpha_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ict}$$

- ▶ Repeated cross-sections (2020, 2023, 2024)
- ▶ Country and wave fixed effects
- ▶ SE clustered at country level
- ▶ Controls: economic perceptions (country and personal), trust, age, and education

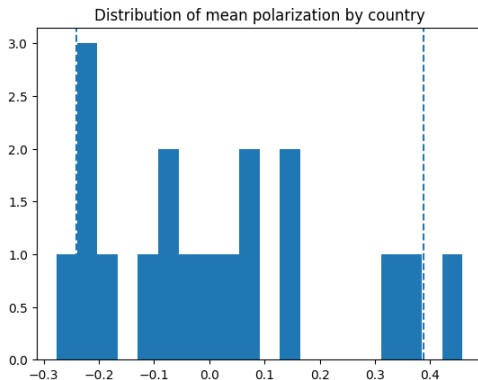
Marginal Effect of Engagement Across Polarization Levels



Robustness: Clustering of Standard Errors

- ▶ Sensitivity to clustering level
- ▶ Model (6), interaction term:
 - ▶ Cluster by country: coefficient = -0.047 , SE = 0.028
 - ▶ Cluster by country-wave: coefficient = -0.047 , SE = 0.023
- ▶ Interpretation:
 - ▶ Coefficient is unchanged
 - ▶ Standard errors slightly smaller with finer clustering
 - ▶ Main result is robust to clustering choice

Robustness: Excluding Outliers



Result:

- ▶ Interaction coefficient remains stable
- ▶ No substantive change in magnitude or significance

Preliminary Findings

- ▶ Preliminary results show a positive association between political engagement and subjective well-being
- ▶ No clear association is observed between happiness and:
 - ▶ individual-level polarization
 - ▶ contextual polarization
 - ▶ being more polarized than others within the same context
- ▶ However, the positive association between political engagement and well-being appears weaker in more polarized contexts
- ▶ This pattern is observed at the contextual level rather than at the individual (within-context) level